

Topic: First Islamic Community.

Sub Topics 1. Scribes and their Work.

Q 1 (a) Describe the work carried out by the Scribes of the Prophet in writing down the revelations and explain why the task they performed was significant. [10] [J/2007]

Points to be Covered in details

➤ Introduction:

- Introduce Scribes: "A group of companions that assisted him in compilation of Holy Verses of Quran and other written tasks"
- Alongside compilation of Quran, they also carried out other written tasks for Prophet (PBUH) like writing treaties and assisting him in formal and informal correspondence.
- If we count all companions who fulfilled some written task at some point of time, the total number would be approx. 40. 7 of them were regular and official. Zaid bin Thabit (RA) (the chief Scribe), Ameer Muaviyah (RA), Ubayy bin Ka'ab (RA) and 4 rightly guided caliphs.
- Once Abdullah bin Amr bin Aas (RA) a famous narrator of Hadith and scribe asked Prophet (PBUH)
📖 "Am I supposed to record everything I hear from you in states of anger and joy?"
📖 "Yes! Nothing comes out of that mouth except truth." Prophet (PBUH) replied while pointing towards his mouth.

➤ Method and Description:

- Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) paid special attention on getting verses of Quran written by these scribes.
- Prophet (PBUH) set some ground rules and adopted a pattern to preserve each and every word of revelation in writing.
- One of these scribes would remain on standby and whenever a verse was revealed, Prophet (PBUH) would call anyone of them and ask to write down the revelation.
- Then they were asked to read it loudly in front of the Prophet (PBUH), so he could listen and recheck if they have recorded it perfectly and rectify if he found any mistake.
- Prophet (PBUH) would also give them clear instructions about the placement and sequence of every single verse that in which surah and which portion a particular verse was supposed to be placed.
- Materials used to write down the revelations were parchments, palm leaves and branches, flat stones, pieces of wood, bones, paper sometimes.
- Zaid bin Thabit the chief scribe sums up the pattern of recording the revelation:
📖 "I used to write down the revelation for the Holy Prophet(PBUH). When the revelation came to him he felt intense heat and drops of perspiration used to roll down his body like pearls. When this state was over I used to fetch a shoulder bone or a piece of something else. He used to go on dictating and I used to write it down. When I finished writing the sheer weight of transcription gave me the feeling that my leg would break and I would not be able to walk anymore. When I finished writing, he would say, 'Read!' and I would read it back to him. If there was an omission or error he used to correct it and then let it be brought before the people."

➤ Significance and Importance of their work:

- Scribes played important role in making sure that every verse is preserved in written.
- As Prophet (PBUH) could not read or write so anyone of the official scribes would stand by so they can instantly record the verses of revelation.
- They did not only focus on written preservation, they also memorized the verses of Quran and would revise it each other. They motivated and assisted other companions to memorize the verses of Holy Quran. God forbids, even if because of some reason written Quran is not widely available, huge number of memorizers of Quran will make sure that a single dot or alphabet of Quran is not wasted or changed.
📖 Allah (SWT) said to Prophet (PBUH): "I am revealing for you a book that water cannot wash away"
- Written compilation of scribes became very important when Quran was being compiled in the era of Abu

Bakr (RA) as those written compilations of Prophet's (PBUH) era were the major and most authentic source of Quran.

Zaid bin Thabit (RA)

- Zaid bin Thabit (RA) was among Helpers (Ansar) of Madinah. He was only 6 years old when his father died in Battle of Buath leaving him orphan.
- He accepted Islam in his childhood and asked permission from Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) to participate in battles of Badr and Uhud. Prophet (PBUH) refused him referring to the minimum age limit of participating in armed encounter which was 15 years.
- Zaid bin Thabit learned to read and write from a prisoner of battle of Badr who was given a chance to teach 10 Muslim children as his ransom and go free.
- Seeing his intelligence, Prophet (PBUH) added him in the group of scribes who were responsible of writing revelations and doing written correspondence on behalf of Prophet (PBUH). Despite being so young, He worked really hard and became the most important and chief scribe of Holy Prophet (PBUH).
- He had excellent command over Arabic, Assyrian and Persian languages. Prophet (PBUH) asked him to learn Hebrew language saying:

📖 "O Zayd! Learn the language of Jews for me"

He learned Hebrew and became sole responsible of correspondence with Jews. He would also write other official letters and treaties whenever instructed by Holy Prophet (PBUH).

- He worked really hard to preserve verses of Holy Quran and transfer them to upcoming generations. He had memorized Quran and also had a written compilation of a part of Quran.
- After the demise of Holy Prophet (PBUH) when 70 companions got martyred who were memorizers of Quran, upon suggestion of Umar (RA) Abu Bakr decided to compile Quran in one booklet. The committee made by Abu Bakr (RA) to execute this enormous and significant task was headed by Zaid bin Thabit (RA). His immediate response was:

📖 "I swear by Allah that if they had offered me to carry a mountain, I would have not found it more difficult than compiling the Quran."

But upon realizing the importance of this task, he left no stone unturned to complete this task in excellent manner. He gathered Quranic verses from bones, parchments, wooden pieces, stones, palm leaves and most importantly from people's hearts. He completed this enormous task in one year and compiled Quran in a single booklet. That booklet was kept by Abu Bakr (RA) then transferred to Umar (RA) then after him to his daughter and Prophet's (PBUH) wife Hafsah (RA). Therefore, it was named Mus'haf-e-Hafsah (The Booklet of Hafsah)

- He was entrusted by Umar (RA) whenever Umar (RA) would go to any expedition, He would designate Zaid (RA) as deputy of Madinah. Umar (RA) said about him:
"The people find in Zayd what they cannot find in other people."
- In the era of Uthman (RA) when Islamic caliphate expanded and different people from different regions of the world started reciting Quran in their different dialects, disputes were observed by Anas bin Malik (RA) and Huzafa (RA) and were reported to Caliph Uthman bin Affan (RA). Uthman (RA) immediately responded to this problem and asked Zaid bin Thabit once again to do the honors. Zaid (RA) once again worked really hard and resolved this issue by selecting a standard dialect of Quran which was the dialect of Quraysh. He rechecked the new book with Mus'haf-e-Hafsah and declared it the standard and official copy of Quran.
- The seekers of knowledge from among the companions of the Prophet and the generation, who succeeded them, came from far and wide to benefit from his knowledge. When Zaid died, Abu Hurairah said: "Today, the scholar of this Ummah has died."
- Zaid bin Thabit died in 45 A.H. Abdullah bin Abbas (RA) said while pointing out towards his grave:

📖 "Many scholars were buried with their knowledge but "Knowledge is buried like this."